Madhya Pradesh
A Greener Heartland

Sensitive leadership creates awareness in the state. An increase in the forest cover came through public participation

Despite the increasing urbanization and expanding scope of industrial development in the country, the news from Madhya Pradesh has brought good cheer to the state and the people. The good news is about an increase in the forest cover of Madhya Pradesh. According to the statistics of the year 2005, the total forest cover of state was 76013 square kilometers and it is 77493 square kilometers in 2021. Also during the course 4239 square kilometer dense forest has gone up to 6665 square kilometers with increase of 63 percent.The fact was revealed in the Forest Survey of India, Dehradun's year 2021 report and now the nature and environment lovers are filled with enthusiasm and hope. Despite all types of anthropogenic pressures, this increase in the forest cover sounds like a great achievement as it is indeed. This achievement somehow also reflects the consistent efforts put forward by the Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shri Shivraj Singh Chouhan and his determination to create awareness about the environment conservation among the common folks. Following the efforts and the movement, the citizens especially the tribal communities living near the forest areas have played a key role in the task.

Shivraj Singh Chouhan's determination for committed plantation catalysed the drive for environmental conservation

Since the beginning of his political career Chief Minister Shri Chouhan has been quite sensitive towards the environment. This change in society has not come overnight. His year-long efforts have resulted in a positive approach to the environment. About 5 years ago, Chief Minister Shivraj initiated a grand movement for plantation which started on a very large scale in the areas around Narmada, the lifeline of the state. For the conservation and protection of the Narmada river, **Namami Devi Narmade - Narmada Seva Yatra** was launched on December 11, 2016, which culminated on May 15, 2017, through this grand event Chief Minister Shri Chouhan mobilized large-scale public participation for the nature and environment conservation across the state. The movement resulted in the cleaning of river water as well as a massive plantation was also undertaken on its banks with enthusiastic support from the people.

This yatra passed through 615 village panchayats, 1100 villages, 51 development blocks, and 16 districts, during which the Chief Minister made 15 important announcements while holding direct dialogue and discussions with the people about the conservation and protection of Narmada. More then 26 lakh people were directly connected with this campaign.

Saplings were planted on the banks of Narmada in a one day plantation drive on 2 July 2017. Also, A total of more than 7 crore saplings were planted by various departments and institutions. Construction of community toilets, changing rooms, and waste management works are also in progress in 16 districts located on the banks of Narmada. Along with boosting development activities through the Narmada Yatra, the CM was also successful in making the society take a stand along with the government to support the cause of environmental conservation according to the climate change. The local people took up the responsibility of protecting the saplings planted on the banks of Narmada. Along with this, greenery was expanded in many districts by planting saplings with public participation.

Jal Sansad was organized by Shri Shivraj Singh in April 2018 for the protection and rejuvenation of 313 minor rivers of the state. The program was followed by the work on all 313 minor rivers. Under this project, development works dedicated to the objectives of deepening, cleaning, and increasing the water level of 313 small rivers of block level are in progress. Madhya Pradesh has also started the construction of 'Amrit Sarovars' based on the vision of Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi under the Amrit Mahotsav and in this sequence work of construction of 5600 Amrit Sarovar or ponds are in progress. Through these Amrit Sarovars, the government's target is to build more water storage capacity which will prove useful for purposes like irrigation, fisheries, water chestnut cultivation, etc.

> *Planting saplings is considered auspicious in our Indian culture. Trees are revered in the Indian worship system as they are believed to be the abode of gods. They are the source of life for every living being. We have understood so far that nature has borne the greatest brunt on account of our injudicious behavior causing alarming damage to the environment. Saving environment is not just a day's job. It is integral to our daily life.*



Shri Shivraj Singh Chouhan
Chief Minister, Madhya Pradesh

The Chief Minister's commitment to the plantation and the environment can be gauged from the fact that over a year back on 19th February 2021, he took a pledge for the protection of the environment. He vowed that he would plant a sapling every day and since then not a single day has passed when Chief Minister Shri Chouhan hasn't planted a sapling. Tree plantation has become a part of his daily morning routine. He plants saplings regularly even when he is not in Bhopal. Whether he is in Bhopal or Delhi, or any other division, district, tehsil, or village, he makes sure to plant a sapling from wherever he stays and this sequence has already completed for one year and the plantation is ever going. Chief Minister Shri Chouhan not only plant saplings but also takes full care of them. He says that ***all the saplings I have planted so far give me the feeling as if they are my children and family members.*** Chouhan's green drive has emerged as an inspiration for the common people and many others have also joined this campaign with him and are continuing to join.

> *Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi has conveyed about making India carbon neutral by 2070 in the COP 26 summit. It's possible when we all together do our part in protecting and conserving the environment. With the aim of realizing the vision of Hon'ble Prime Minister, the massive tree plantation campaign and energy literacy campaign are already initiated on the ground level in the state.*